

CHAPTER 18

Critique, Edit, and Improve



USING AI AGAINST ITS OWN OUTPUT One of the most underused techniques in AI work is asking AI to critique what it has produced.

This sounds circular, and it is, slightly. AI is reviewing its own work, which might seem unlikely to catch errors it didn't notice the first time. But it is more effective than it sounds, for a practical reason: critique mode is a different cognitive stance than generation mode. When you ask AI to switch from producing to evaluating, it activates different patterns and often catches problems it generated in draft mode.

THE CRITIQUE LOOP The basic critique loop has three steps:

STEP 1, PRODUCE A DRAFT Ask AI to produce the draft as normal.

STEP 2, APPLY THE CRITIQUE PROMPT Ask AI to evaluate the draft against explicit criteria. The more specific the criteria, the more useful the critique.

STEP 3, REVISE BASED ON CRITIQUE Ask AI to produce a revised version addressing the issues raised.



THE CRITIQUE PROMPT TEMPLATE

Please review the [document/email/proposal/plan] you just produced.

Evaluate it against the following criteria: [Criterion 1: e.g., Does it clearly address the reader's main concern?] [Criterion 2: e.g., Is the argument in the right order?] [Criterion 3: e.g., Are there claims that could be questioned?] [Criterion 4: e.g., Is there anything missing?] [Criterion 5: e.g., Is the tone right for the audience?]

For each criterion: identify what is working well and what could be improved. At the end: give a one-paragraph overall assessment. Do not be generous. The goal is a better document, not reassurance.

The instruction "do not be generous" matters. Without it, AI tends to produce critique that finds much to praise and softens its concerns. This produces pleasant but not especially useful critique.

WHY IT WORKS CRITIQUE MODE WORKS BETTER THAN IT THEORETICALLY SHOULD BECAUSE AI IS DRAWING ON LARGE BODIES OF

generation mode produces content; critique mode applies editorial judgment.

THE BEFORE -> BETTER -> BEST: CRITIQUE LOOP The scenario: Sarah has used AI to draft a proposal section and wants to improve it before sending.

Stage 1, Draft produced



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[AI produces a draft proposal section about the agency's approach to the client's brief]

Stage 2, Critique applied

Sarah sends: "Please review the proposal section you just drafted. Evaluate it against these criteria: Does it address the client's specific situation or is it generic? Is the argument clear and logical? Are there any claims that aren't supported by what I've told you? Is the tone right for a director-level reader at a mid-size retail company? What's missing? Be direct, I need useful feedback, not reassurance."

AI responds: "A few issues to flag. The opening paragraph describes the agency's general approach rather than the client's specific situation, a sceptical reader will notice you haven't demonstrated understanding of their particular challenge. The 'proven results' claim on page two isn't backed by anything specific in what you've provided. The case study section is good but should come earlier, it's currently buried after the methodology, but for this type of client, demonstrated experience is probably the first thing they want to see. The tone is appropriate throughout."

Stage 3, Revision

Sarah: "Revise the draft addressing these points: lead with the client's situation, move the case study up, remove the 'proven results' claim and replace it with [SPECIFIC RESULT I'LL ADD]."

The resulting revision is substantively better. The critique took two minutes to run. The revision took thirty seconds to instruct. The improvement would have taken Sarah much longer to identify and articulate without the structured critique loop.

SPECIFIC CRITIQUE TYPES Different types of work benefit from different critique focuses:

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FOR PERSUASIVE DOCUMENTS (PROPOSALS, BIDS, PITCHES): "Does this make the reader want to say yes? What objections might they raise? Is the value proposition clear? What is the weakest point

in the argument?"

FOR EXPLANATORY DOCUMENTS (REPORTS, BRIEFINGS, GUIDES): "Is the key finding easy to identify? Is the logic clear? Are there technical terms an educated non-specialist would need explained? Is anything assumed that shouldn't be?"

FOR COMMUNICATIONS (EMAILS, LETTERS, ANNOUNCEMENTS): "Is the purpose of this communication immediately clear? Is the tone right for the relationship? Could anything be misinterpreted? Is there anything missing the recipient will need to act on this?"

FOR CREATIVE OR MARKETING CONTENT: "Is the opening strong enough to keep a reader going? Is there any generic marketing language that a sceptical reader would discount? Is the call to action clear?"

CRITIQUE WITH AN ADVERSARIAL PERSONA For high-stakes documents, a more powerful critique technique is asking AI to adopt a specific adversarial perspective:

"Review this proposal as if you are a procurement director at a large company who has seen hundreds of similar proposals and is looking for reasons to discount this one. What would make you sceptical? What would make you put this in the discard pile?"

"Review this contract clause as if you are a lawyer representing the other party. What would you challenge? What ambiguity would you exploit?"



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"Review this business case as if you are a CFO who has been burned by overoptimistic projections before. What assumptions are too aggressive? What risks are underplayed?"

These adversarial critique prompts produce more rigorous feedback than neutral evaluation and are particularly valuable before anything is presented to an actual sceptical audience.

WATCH OUT AI CRITIQUE HAS TWO CONSISTENT WEAKNESSES. FIRST, IT TENDS TO BE COMPREHENSIVE IN FORMAT BUT IN

the client context it wasn't given, the regulatory nuance that requires specialist knowledge, or the political sensitivities you didn't mention. Use AI critique to catch structural, logical, and stylistic issues. Use human review to catch everything that requires knowledge or judgment AI doesn't have.

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